

The Everywhere Office

They're light on system resources, platform and location independent, and free! Can the new slew of online office applications finally make collaboration easier?

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Teamwork and collaboration are nice words, and are very helpful for the smooth functioning of any organisation. But when you talk about teams spread out over different locations collaborating (or trying to) thanks to technology, you're usually talking locked files, mismatched versions, and the ultimate horror—the wrong version going to the big boss, or even worse, the client! We've all had our share of bad experiences with desktop applications that claim to make document sharing easier, but now that Web 2.0 is upon us, new online applications promise to change that. We've taken a look at Google's three new warriors—Google Calendar (<http://calendar.google.com>), Google Spreadsheets (<http://spreadsheets.google.com>) and Google Docs (<http://docs.google.com>), and a little-known online office suite called Zoho Web 2.0 Office (www.zoho.com).

Spread 'Em

It won't oust Excel from its position yet, but Google Spreadsheets is a compelling online application for creating, editing, and sharing spreadsheets online. It works well in IE and Firefox, but doesn't support Opera, even if you use the "Mask as Mozilla" feature. To start a spreadsheet, all you need is a Google account.

Google Spreadsheets has obviously been designed to make Excel users feel at home—all your oft-used keyboard shortcuts ([Ctrl] + [B] for bold, [Ctrl] + [I] for italics, and so on) are supported, as are formulas. The handy Formulas tab lets you make all the calculations you need as well. When you save the sheet, it gets saved online, and you can save it on your PC by exporting it to Excel, OpenOffice, comma-separated values, even PDF. You can also import your own Excel sheets into Spreadsheet, and for the most part, this function works just fine.

It does encounter problems when importing complex sheets, though—we imported a sheet that was filtered on a person's name, and found that the data hidden by the filter in Excel didn't even make it to the online version.

Where Google Spreadsheets really manages to shine, though, is in what we've been harping about all along—collaboration. You can invite anyone to either view or edit the spreadsheet in real-time—you can all watch the changes that everyone makes, and in the chat panel on the right, discuss the goings-on, call each other names and more. While this can completely plunge into chaos if lots of people are involved—

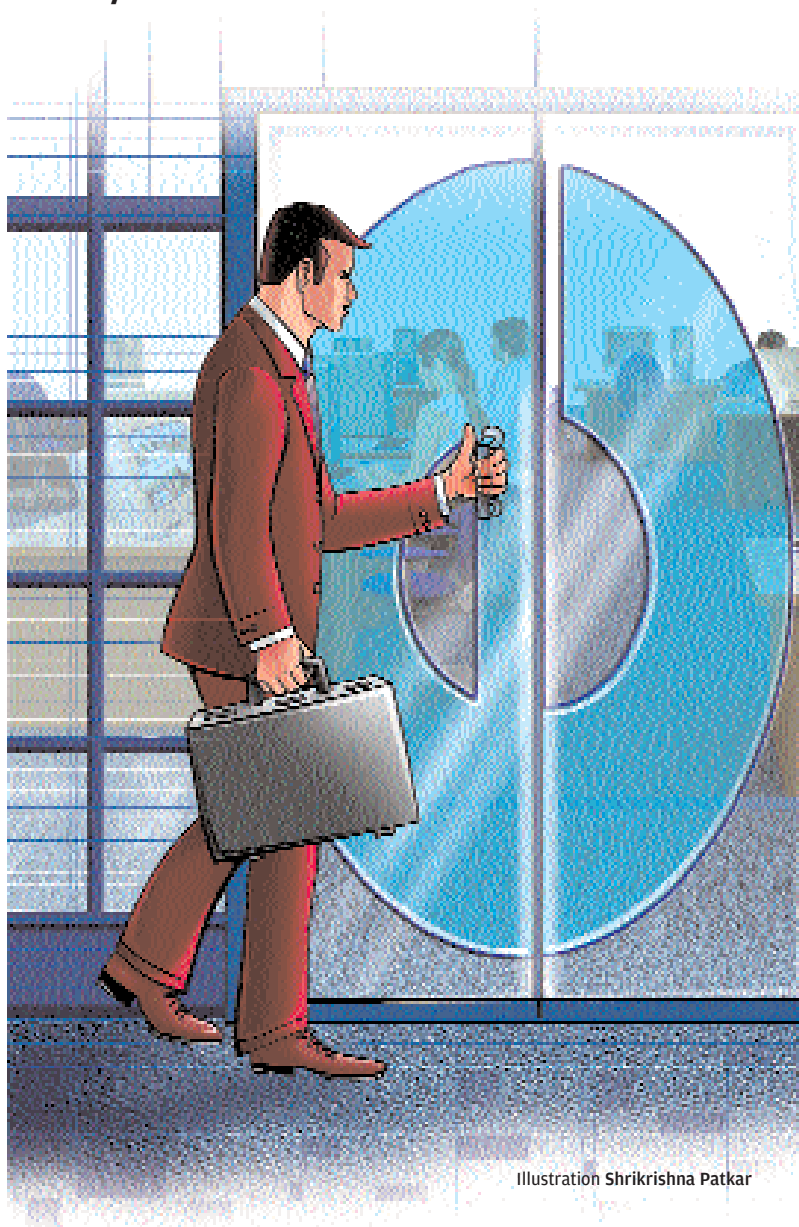


Illustration Shrikrishna Patkar

there's no way to see who made which change—it can be a real help when two or three people need to work on the same spreadsheet.

You can also let the general public view the sheet—just select "Let Everyone View" under Sharing Options, and it gives you a URL that you can then IM or e-mail to anyone.

On the flip side, Google Spreadsheets doesn't support charts (yet), and we encountered the quite ominous "Oops...there was a server error" more times than we'd like. Still, improvements are happening as we write this.